

LOB go-to-market, pricing, and risk

Lumber One Board is a vetted B2B marketplace for forest-products freight: post → book/bid → dispatch → pickup/delivery check-in → mutual close → completion docs. This brief ranks monetization choices against cold-start reality, not against DAT feature parity.

Three assumptions that will kill this if wrong

- 1. Suppliers will not keep posting into an empty carrier pool. Carrier density on a few PNW / mill lanes must come before any paid plan that taxes carriers.
- 2. Charging like a general load board (DAT/Truckstop seat fees) makes LOB a worse, thinner DAT. The wedge is niche trust plus ops lifecycle, not search volume.
- 3. Taking a cut of freight money without broker authority, payment rails, and claims process turns a software product into a regulated brokerage. Do not stumble into that.

Niche board

Positioning

Supply-first

Liquidity strategy

No billing yet

Monetization readiness

Legal draft

Counsel status

Product offering (what we sell today)

Shipped core

- Firm Rate and Open bid posting for mills / wholesalers (SHIPPER).
- Carrier browse, book, bid, capacity offers, DOT/MC/fleet profile (DISPATCHER).
- Dispatch packet, driver haul sheet (rates hidden), carrier pickup/delivery check-in, supplier confirm delivered.
- W-9 / credit reference / insurance intake, admin docs-verified gate, counterparty credit file after shared booking.
- Clickwrap Terms, Privacy, Supplier Agreement, Carrier Agreement (version 2026.09.30-draft).

Explicitly not selling yet

- Customer-facing Insights / market-rate chips (hidden; privacy review).
- In-app email / SMTP (Outlook-manual PDF attach).
- Facility yard QR check-in (deferred; carrier check-in remains).
- Stripe/billing, invoices for platform fees, subscription plans.
- Payments, factoring, or LOB-held freight funds.

Source: docs/STATUS.md · Competitor fee context: public 2026 DAT/Truckstop plan listings (approx. \$42–\$449/user/mo subscription; typically no freight commission).

Go-to-market strategy

Win a dense vertical beachhead, then expand. Do not open a national empty board.

Beachhead

Phase	Focus	Success metric	Duration
0 — Soft launch	3–5 known mills/wholesalers + 15–30 vetted flatbed/Conestoga carriers on overlapping lanes	≥20 completed mutual-close loads / 30 days with <10% no-shows	6–10 weeks
1 — Lane density	One corridor cluster (e.g. PNW mill → Midwest / California receivers)	Median time-to-cover under target; repeat carriers on same lanes	Q1–Q2
2 — Paid conversion	Convert active suppliers to paid seats after they feel coverage; keep carriers free or lightly paid	Paid suppliers covering ≥70% of platform GMV	After Phase 0 proof
3 — Expand	Adjacent regions / product types (panels, engineered wood) using referral from covered mills	Second corridor with same ops quality	After paid retention ≥2 cycles

Who we sell to first

Mid-size mills & wholesalers Primary Enough volume to need a board, not so large that Princeton TMX / private carrier portals already solved tendering. They feel Excel + phone pain.	Asset flatbed fleets Secondary Carriers already hauling lumber who hate ghost loads and double brokers. Sell trust + clean dispatch docs, not another \$149 rate tool.	Mega mills & owner-ops only Defer Mega mills want ERP/EDI tender engines. Solo O/Os churn unless lane density is already high. Both are phase 3+.
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Motion

Motion	Do	Do not
Sales	Founder-led, account-based: mill traffic managers + 2–3 preferred carriers per mill	Self-serve national ads promising "loads nationwide"
Onboarding	White-glove approve after real docs; seed first loads with ops help	Auto-approve on production to inflate vanity users
Product narrative	Trusted forest-products board with dispatch-to-close workflow	Cheaper DAT / better rate analytics (Insights still hidden)
Distribution	Associations, mill networks, Hibernia-style partner intros, lane intel CLI for targeting	Pay-to-post spam to fill the board

Pricing strategies (ranked)

Ranked for a pre-liquidity niche marketplace with no billing product and draft legal. Dollar bands are directional planning figures, not published offers.

#1 recommended — Supplier SaaS + free carriers (density phase)**Ship now path**

Charge the scarce, value-capturing side: mills/wholesalers pay for posting seats, bid management, shipment lifecycle, credit exchange. Carriers free until corridor density is proven.

Plan	Indicative price	Includes
Supplier Starter	\$299–\$499 / company / mo	Post + book workflow, limited seats, credit file, basic shipments
Supplier Ops	\$799–\$1,200 / company / mo	Multi-user, exclusions/tiers, capacity inbox, priority support
Carrier	\$0 during Phase 0–1	Browse, book/bid, capacity, dispatch, check-in

Why #1: Matches who feels pain, avoids DAT seat competition, does not require freight-fund handling. Failure mode: suppliers refuse to pay before coverage exists — so keep free pilot seats until Phase 0 metrics hit.

#2 — Hybrid: free pilot → supplier SaaS + per-completed-load fee

After mutual close, bill shipper a flat success fee (\$35–\$75/load) or small capped % of linehaul (1–1.5%, cap ~\$150). SaaS covers platform; fee aligns with covered freight.

Stronger unit economics if volume grows. Needs invoicing, dispute rules, and counsel on whether the fee is a software transaction fee (preferred) vs brokerage compensation. Do not collect carrier pay.

#3 — Dual subscription (DAT-like)

Suppliers ~\$300–\$800/mo; carriers ~\$49–\$129/mo once density exists. Familiar to the industry.

Premature carrier fees shrink supply of trucks when LOB has less freight than DAT. Only introduce after carriers already get weekly booked miles from LOB.

#4 later — Insights / rate-data add-on

Paid monthly analytics (STATUS already flags this as future). DAT proves data monetizes, but LOB's customer Insights are deliberately hidden pending privacy review. Internal lane intel stays admin-only.

Good year-2 ARPU lever. Bad launch wedge. Selling thin-sample rates damages trust permanently.

#5 avoid**— Freight commission / LOB-as-broker**

Taking 5–15% of linehaul or holding shipper/carrier funds. Forces broker authority, bonding, claims, double-broker exposure, and redefines the company.

Only revisit if LOB deliberately becomes a licensed brokerage with ops headcount. That is a different company.

Risk register and mitigations

Risk	Severity	Why it is real here	Mitigation
Cold-start / empty board	Critical	Two-sided marketplace; forest-products capacity is specialized flatbed	Invite-only beachhead; seed both sides per corridor; free carriers; kill vanity signup marketing
Ghost loads & no-shows	High	Industry-wide board failure mode; kills carrier trust fast	Require mutual close discipline; penalize stale posts; admin cull; track cover-to-complete ratio
Double brokerage / identity fraud	High	Load boards are primary attack surface; LOB has docs but not FMCSA automation depth of Truckstop	Keep production auto-approve off; insurance + credit docs verified; prefer asset carriers early
Legal documents still draft	High	Clickwrap isDraft; counsel pending — monetization and disputes are exposed	Counsel sign-off before paid plans; bump version; clear isDraft; freeze material product claims until then
Accidental brokerage	High	Success fees + dispatch UX can look like arranging transportation for compensation	Structure as software access fee; no holding funds; counsel memo; clear party-of-record language
Admin verification bottleneck	Medium	Approve gate is manual; sales can outrun ops	SLA for docs review; checklist templates; do not loosen gates for growth vanity
No notifications product	Medium	Email deferred; users miss bids/books without Outlook discipline	Keep PDF/Outlook workflow honest; add minimal transactional email or SMS before paid scale
No billing plumbing	Medium	STATUS: do not build Insights billing; there is still no fee collection path	Implement Stripe (or invoice-net-30 for mills) only after Phase 0 proof and counsel OK
Seasonality / soft lumber market	Medium	Volume swings with housing and mill schedules; fire/mud seasons shift lanes	Price annually with quarterly reviews; sell ops reliability over spot volume
Large-mill displacement	Medium	Roseburg-class shippers automate tendering via TMX/ERP, not public boards	Target mid-market; partner as overflow board, not RFP replacement
Data/privacy for Insights	Medium	Lane observations already written; customer Insights deferred for a reason	Keep market chips off until legal/product decision; use admin intel for GTM targeting only
Facility process gap	Low–Med	Yard QR deferred; mill check-in may still be phone/gatehouse	Revisit QR only after carrier check-in proves value; do not block GTM on yard hardware

Product gaps and path forward

Gaps ranked by whether they block revenue or only block scale. Fix blockers before polishing.

Gap	Blocks	Path forward	Order
Counsel-approved legal (clear draft)	Paid launch / disputes	External review of Terms, Supplier, Carrier, Privacy; version bump; isDraft false	1
Liquidity playbook (ops, not code)	Any GTM	Named beachhead accounts, weekly cover report, marketplace-intel targeting	1
Transactional alerts (email/SMS)	Paid retention	Minimal Resend/SMS for book/bid/dispatch events; keep Outlook PDF for docs	2
Billing (SaaS invoices)	Pricing #1–#2	Stripe subscriptions for supplier plans; optional net-30 for mills; no freight wallets	2
Trust score / stale-load hygiene	Carrier retention	Auto-expire posts; completion rate on company; faster admin tools	3
Customer Insights	Upsell only	Privacy review + minimum sample thresholds before any paid analytics	4
Facility QR	Nice-to-have	Validate with 1–2 mills after carrier check-in habit exists	5
EDI / TMS integrations	Enterprise only	Ignore until mid-market SaaS retains; integrations are a trap before density	6

90-day operating plan

Weeks 1–2: counsel kickoff; lock beachhead list; freeze any public Insights claims.

Weeks 3–8: run Phase 0 free for both sides; instrument cover time, completion rate, no-shows; founder sales only.

Weeks 9–12: if Phase 0 metrics hit, pilot Supplier Starter pricing with 2–3 paying mills; carriers stay free; ship billing + minimal alerts.

Kill criteria: if loads do not complete with mutual close, do not monetize. Fix trust and density first.

CEO verdict

LOB should not price like DAT. Sell a vetted forest-products ops board to mid-size suppliers, give carriers free access until lanes are dense, and refuse brokerage economics until counsel and liquidity say otherwise.

Top pricing choice: Supplier SaaS + free carriers, with free pilots until Phase 0 completion metrics are real. Hybrid success fees are the scale-up lever. Dual subscriptions and Insights are later. Freight commissions are a strategic fork, not a tweak.

Competitor pricing cited from public 2026 secondary summaries of DAT One and Truckstop plan pages; confirm live quotes before external use. Product facts from docs/STATUS.md.